

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

What is the recommended storage temperature for frozen fruits and vegetables to maintain best quality?

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ANSWER

0°F (-18°C) or below

FUN FACT

Most frozen fruits and vegetables keep their best quality for 8 to 12 months at this temperature.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

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Adults

Q

Why should you exclude as much air as possible from freezer packages?

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Adults

ANSWER

To limit oxidation and prevent large ice crystals that damage texture and flavor

FUN FACT

Air acts as an insulator and slows freezing, as well as promoting freezer burn.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

What is the purpose of blanching vegetables before freezing?

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Adults

ANSWER

To inactivate enzymes that cause loss of flavor, color, and texture during storage

FUN FACT

Blanching time and temperature depend on the vegetable and should be followed exactly.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

What headspace should be left at the top of a container to allow for expansion when freezing seafood in jars?

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Adults

ANSWER

At least one-half inch

FUN FACT

This prevents glass jars from breaking due to water expanding when it freezes.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

How often should you reglaze frozen fish or shellfish to maintain quality?

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Adults

ANSWER

Every 5 to 6 weeks

FUN FACT

Reglazing with a thin layer of ice protects food from freezer burn during storage.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

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Adults

Q

What is a sign of freezer burn on frozen food?

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Adults

ANSWER

Dry, tough texture with off-flavor, color changes, and odor

FUN FACT

Freezer burn results from moisture loss and oxidation during storage.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

Which type of packaging is NOT recommended for freezing seafood to prevent moisture loss and oxidation?

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Adults

ANSWER

Regular plastic wrap not made for freezer use

FUN FACT

Using packaging designed for the freezer greatly improves frozen food quality.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

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Adults

Q

How long can most frozen fruits and vegetables maintain high quality when stored properly at 0°F (-18°C)?

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Adults

ANSWER

8 to 12 months

FUN FACT

Quality degrades faster if temperature rises even slightly above 0°F.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

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Adults

Q

What is one reason you should not freeze some foods like lettuce or cucumbers?

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

ANSWER

They are high in water and become mushy and unpalatable when thawed

FUN FACT

Foods with high water content often do not freeze well because they suffer texture loss.

Source: SP 50-766 Foods that do not freeze well

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Adults

Q

When freezing seafood, why is vacuum packaging beneficial?

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Adults

ANSWER

It reduces freezer burn and oxidation by removing air

FUN FACT

Vacuum sealing followed by immediate freezing preserves quality best.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

What is the recommended temperature for refrigerators storing perishable foods at home?

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Adults

ANSWER

40°F (4°C) or below

FUN FACT

Keeping refrigerator temperature at 40°F slows bacterial growth significantly.

Source: SP 50-677 Guidelines for the refrigeration of foods

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

Which storage condition helps maintain quality in root cellars for vegetables like carrots and potatoes?

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Adults

ANSWER

Cool temperature with high humidity

FUN FACT

High humidity prevents vegetables from shriveling during storage.

Source: OSU winter crop storage guide

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

Why must tested home freezing recipes not be altered?

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

ANSWER

Because acid, processing time, and texture depend on specific tested methods for safety and quality

FUN FACT

Altering a tested recipe can make it unsafe or cause poor quality.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

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What should you do to minimize freezer burn caused by ice crystal formation during freezer temperature cycling?

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Adults

ANSWER

Use vacuum packaging and minimize air pockets in the package

FUN FACT

Air pockets allow large ice crystals to form, damaging food texture.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

How long can a full freezer of food stay frozen if the power goes out and the door remains unopened?

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Adults

ANSWER

Up to 2 days

FUN FACT

Full freezers stay cold longer because the mass of frozen food keeps temperature down.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

Q

When freezing raw seafood like fish fillets, how should you package individual portions?

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

ANSWER

**Wrap tightly in plastic wrap
and then place in a freezer bag**

FUN FACT

*Individually wrapped portions freeze
and thaw faster and more safely.*

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

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Adults

Q

What is a common consequence if frozen vegetables are thawed above 40°F (5°C) before refreezing?

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

ANSWER

They may become unsafe to eat due to bacterial growth

FUN FACT

Low acidity vegetables support bacterial growth above 40°F, so watch temperatures carefully.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

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Adults

Q

Which vegetable should NOT be stored in a root cellar near onions due to strong odors affecting flavor?

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Adults

ANSWER

Carrots

FUN FACT

Onions and garlic store well together but can cause nearby veggies to take on unwanted flavors.

Source: OSU winter crop storage guide

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Adults

Q

What is the recommended method to protect the top layer of food in containers with a large amount of headspace when freezing?

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

ANSWER

Add fresh water over the frozen bulk after it sets to create a protective ice layer

FUN FACT

Adding water after initial freezing prevents air exposure and quality loss.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

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Adults

Q

Which is the safest way to thaw frozen seafood before cooking?

FREEZING AND COLD STORAGE

Adults

ANSWER

In the refrigerator or under cold running water

FUN FACT

Slow, safe thawing reduces bacterial growth and maintains the best quality.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood